

The Apostolic Case for Jesus as Messiah

Seven Threads of New Testament Testimony,

Tested Against What Israel Already Expected

Translation: New American Standard Bible, 1995 Update (NASB95)

Scripture links: Supporting references are hyperlinked to Blue Letter Bible (NASB95); anchor verses are quoted in full; each section closes with a For Further Study line of additional supporting passages.

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Introduction

A companion study, “The Messianic Hope Fulfilled,” traced eight Old Testament prophetic threads and how they have been read in Jewish tradition — the Mishnah, the Talmud, the Targums, and Maimonides. Those sources are valuable but late: the earliest of them, the Mishnah, was compiled around AD 200, more than a century after the events this paper concerns. This study asks an earlier question — not how later rabbinic Judaism came to read these texts, but what Jesus’ own contemporaries, in the last two centuries before and the first century after His birth, actually expected a coming Messiah to be and do. The evidence for that earlier, “Second Temple” expectation is different in kind: examples like the Dead Sea Scrolls, the Psalms of Solomon, 1 Enoch, and — not least — the Gospels’ and Acts’ own narration of what ordinary people around Jesus expected, including the moments that expectation was disappointed or corrected.

The seven threads below are organized by subject rather than by book, gathering the New Testament’s own presentation — Gospels, Acts, Paul’s letters, Hebrews, and 1 Peter together — under each theme, then asking in turn how closely that presentation matches what was already being said and hoped for among Jesus’ contemporaries. Consistent with the standing theological default for formal commentary in this series, the argument below is developed from a Free Grace / dispensational framework, drawing on Arnold Fruchtenbaum, J. Dwight Pentecost, Charles Ryrie, and the Dallas Theological Seminary faculty commentary tradition. Where a

Reformed covenantal reading meaningfully diverges, a brief alternative is noted by endnote; it is not this paper's own position.

I. Davidic Descent and the Royal Messiah

The New Testament's presentation of Jesus as David's promised heir is its most heavily attested single claim, and its apostolic writers return to it constantly. Matthew opens his entire Gospel with a genealogy tracing that descent ([Matthew 1:1–17](#)); Luke has the angel Gabriel promise Mary that her son will receive “the throne of His father David” and reign “forever” (Luke 1:32–33); Peter's Pentecost sermon argues from God's own oath to David that a descendant would sit on his throne ([Acts 2:29–31](#)); Paul, preaching at Pisidian Antioch, traces the same promise through 2 Samuel and the Psalms ([Acts 13:22–23, 34](#)); and Paul opens his letter to the Romans by identifying the gospel itself with a Son “born of a descendant of David according to the flesh” ([Romans 1:3](#)). Even Revelation's closing chapter has the risen Christ identify Himself, in His own words, as “the root and the descendant of David” ([Revelation 22:16](#)).

*“He will be great and will be called the Son of the Most High; and the Lord God will give Him the throne of His father David;
and He will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and His kingdom will have no end.”*

— Luke 1:32-33, NASB95ⁱ

Arnold Fruchtenbaum treats this thread as the load-bearing claim beneath every other title given to Jesus in the Gospels — the one his contemporaries would have recognized fastest, and argued over hardest.ⁱⁱ Matthew's genealogy and Luke's birth narrative both make this claim their own starting point, before either Gospel says anything else about who Jesus is.ⁱⁱⁱ

How closely this matches Second Temple expectation

Closely — this is the one thread where apostolic proclamation and popular hope are nearly identical in shape. The Psalms of Solomon, written a century or so before Jesus, pray explicitly for a coming “son of David” who will “purge Jerusalem from the nations,” judge in righteousness, and “gather a holy people” under his rule^{iv} — essentially the same expectation Zechariah voices at his own son's birth, hoping for rescue “from the hand of our enemies” ([Luke 1:71](#), 74). The New Testament's argument was never that a Davidic king was coming; every party agreed on that. The argument was over what kind of king he would turn out to be — which is exactly where the next thread begins.

FOR FURTHER STUDY [Matthew 2:5–6](#) (cited by the chief priests and scribes, quoting [Micah 5:2](#)); the oracle behind Peter's and Paul's sermons, [2 Samuel 7:12–16](#) and [Psalm 89:3–4](#); [Isaiah 55:3](#); [Romans 9:5](#); and [Hebrews 1:5](#) (applying [Psalm 2:7](#) and [2 Samuel 7:14](#) to the Son).

II. Suffering, Rejection, and Atoning Death

Jesus predicts His own death and resurrection well before Jerusalem ([Mark 8:31](#)); Peter tells the crowd at Solomon's Portico that God had “announced beforehand by the mouth of all the

prophets” that His Christ would suffer ([Acts 3:18](#)); Philip explains [Isaiah 53](#) directly to the Ethiopian eunuch as being about Jesus ([Acts 8:32–35](#)); Paul states as received tradition that “Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures” ([1 Corinthians 15:3](#)); and Peter’s first letter draws its language of healing wounds and going astray like sheep directly from Isaiah 53 ([1 Peter 2:21–25](#)). Hebrews adds that it was fitting for God to perfect “the author of their salvation... through sufferings” ([Hebrews 2:9–10](#)).

“But He was pierced through for our transgressions, He was crushed for our iniquities; The chastening for our well-being fell upon Him, and by His scourging we are healed.”

— [Isaiah 53:5](#), NASB95

Jesus’ own disciples did not expect this. When He first predicts His death plainly, Peter “took Him aside and began to rebuke Him, saying, ‘God forbid it, Lord! This shall never happen to You’” — to which Jesus answers, “Get behind Me, Satan!” ([Matthew 16:21–23](#)).^v

How closely this matches Second Temple expectation

This is the sharpest divergence of all seven threads. There is little pre-Christian evidence that Isaiah 53 was read as describing a suffering, dying individual Messiah rather than Israel corporately, the reading later rabbinic sources settle into.^{vi} A single fragmentary Qumran text (4Q285) has occasionally been read as describing a slain messianic figure, but the reading is genuinely disputed among scholars and was, at most, a fringe possibility rather than a circulating hope.^{vii} The New Testament’s own narrative is honest about the gap: two disciples, walking away from Jerusalem after the crucifixion, say — past tense — “we were hoping that it was He who was going to redeem Israel” ([Luke 24:21](#)) — meaning the death itself had looked like proof He wasn’t the one, until the risen Christ Himself “explained to them the things concerning Himself in all the Scriptures,” beginning with Moses ([Luke 24:27](#)).

FOR FURTHER STUDY Also part of this thread’s own witness: [Mark 14:61–62](#); [Luke 24:26, 44–46](#); [Acts 17:3](#); [Acts 26:22–23](#); [1 Peter 1:10–11](#); [Hebrews 5:8](#); and [Hebrews 9:26–28](#).

III. Resurrection

Peter’s Pentecost sermon and Paul’s sermon at Pisidian Antioch both make the identical argument from the same psalm: David wrote that God’s “Holy One” would not “undergo decay,” but David himself died and was buried and his tomb was still there — so the psalm must speak of someone else’s resurrection ([Acts 2:29–31](#); [Acts 13:34–37](#)). Paul later states the resurrection as settled apostolic teaching, “raised on the third day according to the Scriptures” ([1 Corinthians 15:4](#)), and opens Romans by calling it the very thing that “declared” Jesus “the Son of God with power” ([Romans 1:4](#)).

“For You will not abandon my soul to Sheol; Nor will You allow Your Holy One to undergo decay.”

— [Psalm 16:10](#), NASB95

How closely this matches Second Temple expectation

Partially. A general resurrection of the righteous at the end of the age was a real, mainstream Jewish hope in Jesus’ day — the Pharisees affirmed it and the Sadducees famously denied it

([Acts 23:6–8](#)). One remarkable Qumran fragment even describes God’s coming agent as one who will “heal the wounded” and “revive the dead”, language close enough to Isaiah 61 that Jesus points to matching deeds as His own answer to John the Baptist ([Matthew 11:4–5](#)).^{viii} What has no real precedent is the specific claim this thread makes: not a future hope for all the righteous at history’s end, but one particular man’s bodily resurrection, in the middle of history, offered as present proof of who he already was.

FOR FURTHER STUDY Also see [Hebrews 13:20](#) — the risen Christ “brought up from the dead... through the blood of the eternal covenant.”

IV. Exaltation, Sonship, and Lordship

At His own trial, Jesus applies Daniel’s heavenly “Son of Man” and the enthroned figure of Psalm 110 to Himself in a single breath ([Mark 14:62](#)). Peter’s Pentecost sermon reaches its climax on the same psalm: “God has made Him both Lord and Christ” ([Acts 2:33–36](#)). Paul’s hymn in Philippians ends with every knee bowing, echoing Isaiah’s own language for God alone ([Philippians 2:9–11](#)), and Hebrews returns to Psalm 110:1 again and again as its own argument’s climax ([Hebrews 1:3–4](#), [13](#); [Hebrews 10:12–13](#)).

“The LORD says to my Lord: “Sit at My right hand Until I make Your enemies a footstool for Your feet.”

— **Psalm 110:1, NASB95**

Psalm 110 is quoted or echoed in the New Testament more often than any other single Old Testament chapter — a scholarly observation, not a devotional one, and a fair measure of how much theological weight the apostolic writers placed on this thread specifically.^{ix} Ryrie treats this convergence of offices — prophet, priest, and enthroned king — as the heart of biblical Christology: no single Old Testament office fully anticipated it on its own.^x

How closely this matches Second Temple expectation

Better attested than the Suffering Servant thread, though still not the mainstream picture. The Dead Sea Scrolls community expected not one exalted figure but three: “a prophet and the Messiahs of Aaron and Israel” — a priestly messiah and a kingly messiah, kept distinct.^{xi} A separate apocalyptic tradition, the Similitudes of 1 Enoch, does describe a pre-existent, heavenly “Son of Man” enthroned in glory — real precedent for reading Daniel 7 as more than a symbol^{xii} — but this belonged to a narrow visionary literature, not popular belief. The New Testament’s distinct move is collapsing all of this — prophet, priest, king, and heavenly judge — into one figure, and doing so within a generation of a recently crucified teacher’s death.

FOR FURTHER STUDY [Daniel 7:13–14](#) — the heavenly “Son of Man” vision behind Mark 14:62; [Isaiah 45:23](#) — the “every knee will bow” language Paul applies to Christ; and [Revelation 5:5–6](#) — the Lion of Judah and Root of David revealed as the slain Lamb.

V. Priesthood and the New Covenant

At the Last Supper, Jesus Himself identifies the cup as “the new covenant in My blood” ([Luke 22:20](#); [1 Corinthians 11:25](#)), invoking Jeremiah directly.^{xiii} Hebrews spends its longest sustained argument establishing why a non-Levitical priest-king was always implied in Israel’s own Scripture — resolved through the figure of Melchizedek ([Hebrews 5:5–6](#); [7:1–17](#)) — and then quotes Jeremiah’s new-covenant promise in full as the basis for a better covenant altogether ([Hebrews 8:6–13](#)).

“The LORD has sworn and will not change His mind, “You are a priest forever According to the order of Melchizedek.”

— [Psalm 110:4](#), NASB95

Jeremiah’s own promise stands behind Hebrews’ second argument: “I will put My law within them and on their heart I will write it... for I will forgive their iniquity, and their sin I will remember no more” ([Jeremiah 31:33–34](#)).^{xiv}

How closely this matches Second Temple expectation

Genuinely present, in a different key. The Qumran community described itself, in its own founding documents, as already living under “the new covenant in the land of Damascus” — direct proof that Jeremiah 31’s language was claimed as present reality by a real community before Christianity existed.^{xv} And Qumran’s expectation of a priestly “Messiah of Aaron” alongside its kingly messiah^{xvi} shows a priestly-messianic figure was a live category, not a Christian invention. What is new is Hebrews’ specific argument that priesthood and covenant converge in one person — an argument built on a real textual anomaly (Genesis 14’s Melchizedek, and Psalm 110:4 itself) rather than manufactured from nothing, but a use of that anomaly no other surviving Second Temple source makes.^{xvii}

FOR FURTHER STUDY [Hebrews 9:11–15](#) — Christ as “the mediator of a new covenant.”

VI. Prophet Like Moses and Authoritative Teacher

At the Transfiguration, God’s own voice tells the disciples, “This is My beloved Son... listen to Him!” ([Matthew 17:5](#)) — deliberately echoing Deuteronomy’s command to heed the coming prophet. Peter cites that Deuteronomy passage directly at Solomon’s Portico ([Acts 3:22–23](#)), and Stephen repeats it in his own defense before the Sanhedrin ([Acts 7:37](#)). Hebrews opens by contrasting how God spoke through the prophets of old with how He has now spoken, in these last days, through the Son ([Hebrews 1:1–2](#)).

“The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your countrymen, you shall listen to him.”

— [Deuteronomy 18:15](#), NASB95

How closely this matches Second Temple expectation

Real, if narrower than the Davidic hope. The Samaritans held their own version of this expectation — a returning Moses-like restorer-teacher called the Taheb — reflected directly in

the Samaritan woman's own words to Jesus: "I know that Messiah is coming... He will declare all things to us" ([John 4:25](#)).^{xviii} Qumran's own three-figure expectation likewise includes "a prophet" distinct from its two messiahs.^{xix} So this thread was a recognized, circulating category among Jesus' contemporaries — narrower than the mainstream royal expectation covered in Thread I, but not a New Testament invention.^{xx}

FOR FURTHER STUDY [Deuteronomy 18:15–19](#) in full — the passage both Peter and Stephen cite directly.

VII. Light to the Nations and Inclusion of the Gentiles

Simeon, holding the infant Jesus in the Temple, blesses God for a salvation prepared "in the presence of all peoples," a light "of revelation to the Gentiles" ([Luke 2:32](#)). Paul and Barnabas, rejected by the synagogue at Pisidian Antioch, turn directly to Isaiah's own words to justify preaching to Gentiles instead ([Acts 13:47](#)), and Paul closes his letter to the Romans with his own catena of Old Testament texts on Gentile inclusion ([Romans 15:8–12](#)).

"I will also make You a light of the nations So that My salvation may reach to the end of the earth."

— [Isaiah 49:6](#), NASB95

Paul and Barnabas quote this verse to the Jewish leadership at Pisidian Antioch almost word for word: "I HAVE PLACED YOU AS A LIGHT FOR THE GENTILES, THAT YOU MAY BRING SALVATION TO THE END OF THE EARTH" ([Acts 13:47](#)).^{xxi}

How closely this matches Second Temple expectation

Mixed. The underlying idea — that the nations would eventually acknowledge Israel's God — has deep roots in Isaiah itself and recurs across Second Temple Jewish literature; it was not a novel concept. But it was almost always pictured as Gentiles coming *to* Israel, on Israel's terms, submitting to Israel's God and generally to the Mosaic Law, at history's end. Paul's specific argument — that Gentiles are grafted in *now*, as full co-heirs, without adopting the Law as a condition — was itself sharply contested among Jewish believers, the very dispute that dominates Acts 15 and the letter to the Galatians ([Galatians 3:8, 16](#)). The raw hope of Gentile inclusion is old; the law-free, immediate, co-equal shape Paul gives it was itself new and disputed.

FOR FURTHER STUDY The underlying hope traces back to [Isaiah 42:6](#); see also [Acts 28:28](#); Paul's own catena in [Romans 15:9–12](#) ([2 Samuel 22:50](#); [Deuteronomy 32:43](#); [Psalm 117:1](#); [Isaiah 11:10](#)); and [Genesis 12:3](#); [18:18](#), the Abrahamic promise Paul traces the whole argument back to.

Conclusion: A Selective Fulfillment, Not a Foregone Conclusion

Measured against what Jesus' own contemporaries actually expected — not the later rabbinic tradition surveyed in this paper's companion study, but the Dead Sea Scrolls, the Psalms of Solomon, 1 Enoch, and the Gospels' own narration of popular hope — five of these seven

threads have real, attested roots in the world Jesus entered: the Davidic King, a general resurrection hope, an exalted heavenly figure, a priestly-messianic and covenant-renewal expectation, and a prophet-like-Moses figure were all, in some form, already circulating. The apostles were not inventing categories from nothing.

But at nearly every one of those points the New Testament's specific claim goes further than, or against the grain of, the popular version of the same hope — and at one point, the Suffering Servant, it appears to have had no real popular precedent at all. The Gospels do not hide this: they show it catching Jesus' own disciples by surprise, provoking Peter's rebuke ([Matthew 16:22](#)) and the Emmaus travelers' disappointed hope ([Luke 24:21](#)).

ⁱUnless otherwise noted, all Scripture quotations are taken from the New American Standard Bible: 1995 Update (La Habra, CA: The Lockman Foundation, 1995), hereafter cited as NASB95.

ⁱⁱArnold G. Fruchtenbaum, *Messianic Christology* (Tustin, CA: Ariel Ministries, 2010), on the Davidic Covenant and the nature of messianic prophecy generally.

ⁱⁱⁱ"The Messiah Would Be a Descendant of David," *Jews for Jesus*, January 1, 2018, <https://jewsforjesus.org/messianic-prophecies/the-messiah-would-be-a-descendant-of-david>.

^{iv}R. B. Wright, trans., "Psalms of Solomon," in *The Old Testament Pseudepigrapha*, vol. 2, ed. James H. Charlesworth (Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1985), 639–670, esp. 17:21–32, 45. Psalm of Solomon 17 (1st century BC) prays for a "son of David" who will "purge Jerusalem from the nations," "gather a holy people" under his rule, and "judge the tribes of the people that has been sanctified by the Lord his God" — a strongly political-military reading of the Davidic hope current within a century or so of Jesus' birth.

^vJ. Dwight Pentecost, *Things to Come: A Study in Biblical Eschatology* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1958; repr., Grand Rapids: Academie Books, 1980), on the pattern of humiliation preceding exaltation running through messianic prophecy.

^{vi}"The Rabbis' Dilemma: A Look at Isaiah 53," *Jews for Jesus*, September 1, 1982, <https://jewsforjesus.org/learn/the-rabbis-dilemma-a-look-at-isaiah-53>. Frydland documents that a suffering, dying individual Messiah was, at best, a minority reading within Jewish interpretation, then and since — the majority reading (Israel-as-servant) is attested from the earliest rabbinic sources onward.

^{vii}The single fragmentary Qumran text sometimes read as describing a slain Messiah — 4Q285, part of the War Scroll tradition — is genuinely disputed among scholars. Robert Eisenman and Michael Wise's initial translation (*The Dead Sea Scrolls Uncovered* [Rockport, MA: Element, 1992]) rendered it as "they shall put to death the Leader of the Community," but Geza Vermes and other scholars argued the grammar more likely has the messianic figure doing the killing, not suffering it; see the exchange documented in "More on the Pierced Messiah Text from Eisenman and Vermes," *Biblical Archaeology Review*, and Geza Vermes, trans., *The Complete Dead Sea Scrolls in English*, 7th ed. (London: Penguin Classics, 2011). At most a contested, fringe reading — not a popular expectation.

^{viii}4Q521 ("Messianic Apocalypse") describes an agent of God who will "heal the wounded, revive the dead, and preach good news to the poor" — language closely paralleling Isaiah 61 and the very words Jesus points to in His answer to John the Baptist (cf. Matthew 11:4–5; Luke 7:22). See "4Q521," Wikipedia, accessed September 2026, <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/4Q521>; text in Vermes, *The Complete Dead Sea Scrolls in English*. General end-time resurrection, however, is a broader hope than the specific NT claim of one man's resurrection in the middle of history as present proof of His identity — cf. Acts 23:6–8 on the Pharisees' own belief in a future resurrection.

^{ix}David M. Hay, *Glory at the Right Hand: Psalm 110 in Early Christianity*, SBL Monograph Series 18 (Nashville: Abingdon Press, 1973). Hay's study remains the standard treatment documenting Psalm 110 as the Old Testament chapter most frequently quoted or echoed in the New Testament.

^xCharles C. Ryrie, *Basic Theology*, rev. ed. (Chicago: Moody Publishers, 1999), on the person and offices of Christ.

^{xi}1QS ("Rule of the Community") 9:11 anticipates "the coming of a prophet and the Messiahs of Aaron and Israel" — a priestly messiah and a kingly messiah as two distinct figures, alongside a separate prophetic figure. Geza Vermes, trans., *The Complete Dead Sea Scrolls in English*, 7th ed. (London: Penguin Classics, 2011).

^{xii}1 Enoch 37–71 (the Similitudes of Enoch) describes a pre-existent, heavenly "Son of Man" enthroned in glory who judges the nations — real precedent for reading Daniel 7's figure as more than a symbol, though confined to an apocalyptic literary circle rather than popular belief. George W. E. Nickelsburg and James C. VanderKam, trans., *1 Enoch: A New Translation* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2004). The Similitudes are also the one section of 1 Enoch never found among the Qumran Aramaic fragments (unlike the rest of the book); J. T. Milik once argued on that basis that they were a late Christian composition, but that view was rejected by the 1977–78 SNTS Pseudepigrapha Seminar, and the section is now usually dated Jewish and pre-Christian, most commonly to the first century AD — though its precise date and relationship to Gospel "Son of Man" language remains debated.

^{xiii}On whether this is the same covenant Jeremiah foretold or a separate one: some older dispensational writers held there were two new covenants — one for Israel, fulfilled in a future kingdom, and a distinct one inaugurated here for the Church — chiefly to keep Israel's national promises from being read as transferred to the Church. Most dispensational scholars today, including the sources cited throughout this paper, hold instead that there is one new covenant, the very one Jeremiah foretold, inaugurated in Christ's blood; believers already share its spiritual benefits now while the covenant's full national and territorial fulfillment for Israel remains future. See Ryrie, *Basic Theology*, on the new covenant.

^{xiv}John F. Walvoord and Roy B. Zuck, eds., *The Bible Knowledge Commentary: New Testament* (Wheaton, IL: Victor Books, 1983).

^{xv}"The Damascus Document" (CD), a Qumran community rule, repeatedly describes its own community as living under "the new covenant in the land of Damascus" (CD 6:19; 8:21; 19:33–34; 20:12) — direct evidence that Jeremiah 31's "new covenant" language was already claimed as present reality by a real Jewish community before Christianity existed, though understood as a stricter, purer keeping of the Mosaic Torah rather than a covenant sealed by one man's atoning blood. Geza Vermes, trans., *The Complete Dead Sea Scrolls in English*, 7th ed. (London: Penguin Classics, 2011).

^{xvi}1QS 9:11, again. Geza Vermes, trans., *The Complete Dead Sea Scrolls in English*, 7th ed. (London: Penguin Classics, 2011).

^{xvii}For a Reformed covenantal alternative to the dispensational reading of the New Covenant assumed in this paper — one that reads Jeremiah 31 as fulfilled organically in the Church as the continuation of Israel, rather than a future, ethnically distinct Israel — see Michael S. Horton, *The Christian Faith: A Systematic Theology for Pilgrims on the Way* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 2011), on the new covenant and its fulfillment in the church. This paper follows the Free Grace / dispensational reading (Fruchtenbaum, Pentecost) as its own stated position; the Reformed reading is noted here for academic contrast only.

^{xviii}On the Samaritan expectation of a returning Moses-like prophet-teacher (the Taheb, "the one who returns/restores"), see Jarl E. Fossum, *The Samaritan Messiah: Anticipated Prophet and Present Redeemer according to Early Samaritan Sources*, *Coniectanea Biblica New Testament Series 16* (Tübingen: J. C. B. Mohr, 1985); cf. John 4:25 itself, where the Samaritan woman states the expectation directly.

^{xix}1QS 9:11, again. Vermes, *The Complete Dead Sea Scrolls in English*.

^{xx}"The Messiah Would Be a Prophet Like Moses," *Jews for Jesus*, January 1, 2018, <https://jewsforjesus.org/messianic-prophecies/the-messiah-would-be-a-prophet-like-moses>.

^{xxi}Walvoord and Zuck, eds., *The Bible Knowledge Commentary: New Testament*.